

warriors who want movies and music on the go. We have the gimmicky players for the show-off in you, and the fashionable “as hot as you are” players! We even have suitable workout companions. We selected 36 PMPs to test from amongst the multitude of options available. Creative couldn't send us any models for this test, but you can be sure that we'll cover them in the coming months.

Lately, Flash memory has become a lot cheaper, and everyone is basing products on it. Sharply declining prices coupled with steeply rising densities may mean hard drive based PMPs will become extinct soon. Of our contestants, 33 were Flash-based, and only three were hard drive based, including one microdrive-based player from MobiBlu.

TINY MIGHT! **Up to Rs 4,000**

By far the most populous category featuring 12 players, this was also the “hot” category as far as price goes, and most of our readers taking the portable media plunge will be shopping within this price bracket.

Surprisingly, features weren't in short sup-

As we discovered performance and features weren't always mutually exclusive

the sub-4000 category—three different capacity avatars of their YMP-18 and one unique-looking YMP-35, that looks like it's folded in the middle.

The YMP-18 has a single colour LED screen that would have looked bland if not for the changing backlight colours at every press of a button. A siren to some, garish to others—our opinions were about even. The screens on the Mitashi MPL-1004, Eurone 838S and the YES YMP-35 are all quite good and easily readable. Not surprisingly, this trio also plays video, which explains both the relatively better quality of the screen and the larger dimensions.

What Can You Offer Me?

In keeping with the times, all the players in this category feature FM tuners, except for the diminutive Upro AMP-777. The YES YMP-18 supports multiple recording possibilities, from the inbuilt microphone, line-in and the FM radio. Dual headphone jacks mean there's enough music for two! The 1 GB Mitashi MPL 1004 is the only player to feature expansion; this is a welcome add-on, since the bigger screen and interface will hint at emphasis on the space-gobbling video-player capabilities. Its cheaper sibling, the

ply here, and some of the contestants offer superb value for money.

Features **It's all about the look...**

The tiny Intex Aura is the smallest player in our shootout to feature an LCD. Despite this, it is built to stand the rigours of daily use well. A tiny bit larger is the MobiBlu DAH-2100—equally well built, this one. But the smallest of the bunch is the very iPod Shuffle-like Eurone Upro AMP-777. Built like a little tank and featuring a clip-on style fastener, this player's button layout is identical to that of the Shuffle. The colour combination risks dirt—pure white and silver—but we liked it.

The Mitashi MPF1001 resembles a USB pen drive albeit with an OLED screen—compact yet practical. The Root VJE-1GB has a beautifully chromed rear that should be an unparalleled scratch magnet. This player's weight also led us to suspect the rear was solid steel—not bad. Speaking of weight, the YMP-18 (YES) is the lightest of the bunch by far—in fact, without its AAA battery, this featherweight seems insubstantial in one's pocket.

YES managed to squeeze four players into

